

Saskatoon surgery professor suspended, terminated from key roles

The SHA and the U of S take action against Dr. Francis Christian over his public statements on COVID-19 and vaccines.

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Dr. Francis Christian, a surgery professor at the University of Saskatchewan, speaks at a press conference outside Walter Murray Collegiate for a group called Concerned Parents Saskatchewan to address their issues with students being vaccinated in Saskatoon, Thursday, June, 17, 2021. Dr. Chong Wong, who is also seen in this photo, also lectures at the University of Saskatchewan. Kayle Neis/[^]Saskatoon StarPhoenix PHOTO BY KAYLE NEIS /Saskatoon StarPhoenix

Article content

A Saskatoon surgery professor who has publicly questioned the severity of the COVID-19 pandemic and the safety of vaccines has been suspended and terminated from key positions.

The Saskatchewan Health Authority said Wednesday it has terminated its contract with Dr. Francis Christian, who occupied a key role in the organization with respect to surgery.

The University of Saskatchewan released a statement on Wednesday from the dean of the College of Medicine, Preston Smith, saying Christian has been suspended while his “recent actions and public statements” are reviewed.

Smith said the suspension follows U of S policies, so Christian has been removed from his faculty responsibilities and his two academic administrative roles within the department of surgery.

“The university encourages public debate of important societal issues,” Smith’s statement says. “However ... our medical faculty are subject to the ethical and professional standards governing the practice of medicine, and USask is responsible to review concerns raised about its medical faculty in relation to these standards.”

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Christian is a clinical professor of surgery in the department of surgery. His profile on the U of S website had been altered on Wednesday to reflect the suspension.

Christian had been serving as the director of quality improvement and patient safety in the department of surgery, and with the SHA. He had also served as editor of the Journal of the Surgical Humanities, another responsibility that has been removed from his profile.

The emailed statement from the SHA says the organization will co-operate with the U of S to review Christian's behaviour.

"While we respect that residents of Saskatchewan have a right to free speech, health system leaders are expected to be committed to fact-based, scientifically driven public messaging," the SHA message says. "Given the risks of COVID, leaders who depart from this commitment in favour of conspiracy theories put lives at risk by potentially discouraging uptake on life-saving vaccines."

The SHA's contract with Christian will expire on Sept. 21, following the required 90 days notice.

Christian has not responded to messages sent to him this week.

He appeared in a video posted earlier this month to the website BitChute that has received nearly 70,000 views.

In the video, Christian and other Canadian doctors question the mainstream narrative about the COVID-19 pandemic and the vaccines developed to control it.

Christian mocks restrictions intended to prevent the spread of COVID-19, questions whether the pandemic is genuine and calls the vaccines “experimental injections.”

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Health Canada has authorized four COVID-19 vaccines for use.

“Our decisions are based only on scientific and medical evidence showing that vaccines are safe and effective,” a statement on the federal government’s website says.

Last week, Christian joined with a group trying to stop the vaccination of youth in Saskatchewan. He read from a prepared statement in front of Walter Murray Collegiate, but declined to take questions from journalists.

“In light of this situation, the SHA would like to reaffirm that it does not support or endorse spreading misinformation that casts doubt on the seriousness of COVID-19, the validity of the science of this pandemic, and the effectiveness of COVID vaccinations,” the SHA message says.

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